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Donn Andre

Donn Andre is a 1958 graduate of Hamilton College, a banjo player and lifelong fan and performer of Dixieland jazz. He is a member, with other Hamilton alums, of the Alumni All-Stars Jazz Band, one of the longest running ensembles in the nation. Donn makes his home in Derwood, Maryland, and has performed for many years with the Washington, DC-based band, the Federal Jazz Commission.

Donn was interviewed in Clinton, NY on June 6, 2009, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe, Director of the Jazz Archive here at Hamilton College. I am please to be meeting with Donn Andre today, class of '58.

DA: Right.

MR: Torch bearer for the Alumni Jazz Band and traditional jazz in general.

DA: Yes, I came to the hill in 1954 and I had had a little experience playing guitar and ukulele and banjo, just a bunch of kids hacking around, and I got up here and I was in Carnegie and I heard a banjo upstairs the first night and I went up and a kid was playing a tenor. And I said could I play it? And a fellow in the room said, "Hey, I gotta tell Emerson Brown about you." Who is Emerson Brown? I didn't know and he said, "Well you know we have a jazz band here called the Catatonic Five." And I said, "Oh, that's interesting." So the next day Emerson showed up to my room and said, "How would you like to come down to Paul Parker's house tomorrow for a rehearsal?" And I said fine. So I went down there and it was Paul Parker the art professor, rest his soul, playing piano, he was a barrel house Chicago-style player, and his son Mike on trumpet, and the other son, Larry, on bass, and a young fellow named Dick Sherman — not the Dick Sherman of today, but a kid from Clinton High School named Skooky Sherman. And so we started to play and said hey, I think we've got a banjo player. I said well that's great because I've never really been in a band before. So from there on we started getting gigs and I went down to Utica to a hock shop and bought a really awful banjo, which I played. And then the college used us for a concert Friday night of winter carnival weekend, right after the basketball game and in the Class of '55 yearbook in the page that says activities or entertainment or whatever, after, there is a two page photograph of the band on the stage in Commons.

MR: Oh, how neat. So there were six or seven people in the band at that time?

DA: At that point we had, let's see Pete Ziefelt I think was playing piano, me and Emerson, so that makes three, Larry Parker — yeah there were six. Larry and Mike Parker and Skooky Sherman.

MR: What did you call the music?

DA: Dixieland.

MR: Okay. And you know we had a brief conversation about this. I'm still trying to sort out in my head how you guys thought of this music at that time. Because in retrospect it seems like well you were playing music that dates back a long time. But you didn't really think of it as dated.

DA: No. I really didn't think of it as dated, and I lived in New York there, on Long Island, and the clubs in New York City which were experiencing the Dixieland revival period, if you will, the Condon band and Max Kaminsky and there was Nick's in Central Plaza and Jimmy Ryan's — there was a whole lot of Dixieland being played at the time, at the same time that what people were calling progressive was being played. And so we would, as teenagers, go into New York City to the clubs, and we just had a ball listening to Condon and squandering our little earned money. And we just loved the music, and we would gather sometimes at friends' houses and flip on the Firehouse Five Plus Two, or some of the Condon records, or Goodman's '38 jazz concert, which we all loved, even though it wasn't Dixieland. There was a Dixieland portion in that program but we loved swing, because it was melodic, it was rhythmic, and it was just something that touched us and it didn't touch everybody. I mean there were a lot of my high school friends who either didn't understand the music or didn't like it or whatever. And very few of us were players. And even here at college we had a couple of groups going, but our group, the Catatonic Five, was the one that seemed to catch on for the fraternity parties. But why we all gravitated toward this music as opposed to progressive is a very difficult question. I have to admit that I really enjoyed progressive music at the time as well, although I said I play the banjo because I can't play that other stuff.

MR: You mean like Charlie Parker?

DA: Yeah, Charlie Parker, or well I remember taking my girlfriend, who later became my wife, her first experience in a jazz idiom in New York City we went to this place called The Composer and heard Mary Lou Williams, a black piano player, wonderful, Edmund Thigpen on drums and Whitey Mitchell was on bass. And she just really enjoyed that. But it was not Dixieland.

MR: Right. Mary Lou Williams was fairly progressive always.

DA: Yes.

MR: Was there a distinction with you guys in the listening end of it between Bunk Johnson type black jazz and white players? Was there any distinction?

DA: No. There really wasn't. In fact, because my introduction to it, if you will, was through the bands who were playing Dixieland and traditional jazz in the late 40s and 50s, I really didn't pay much attention to the earlier stuff. In fact some of the records, and some of my

friends will shoot me for this, I really didn't like Louis Armstrong. Now I really appreciate him, very much so. But there was just something that was just a little, it didn't quite swing the way the Condon band swung. And I was more interested in the rhythm. In fact, I used to play the drums in a marching band, so I had always been interested in rhythms and drums. So that's why I have an instrument that has a head on it.

MR: Was the Condon band, perhaps, had some swing influence to it?

DA: Well yeah I would think so. And I think primarily the swing influence was Eddie Condon himself. He played a wonderful four-string plectrum guitar that was specially made for him by Gibson, but this was after he had already learned banjo and gravitated toward a plectrum guitar. But it was that swinging guitar that really propelled the band, I think, except he had sterling drummers: George Wettling and Cliff Leeman, and people like that. So yeah I think that was the aspect to it that really got to me. We felt it was more two-beat than four-beat.

MR: Okay. You felt which was more two-beat?

DA: What we liked and what we played. And that influence is with me today, because I'm not a four-beat banjo player. I'm really — I play the banjo kind of like the way a drummer plays the drums, you know, that kind of thing. And then as I got farther into the music and got influenced by some of my colleagues, I began to appreciate the older stuff and the older musicians, and of course I was way behind the power curve in terms of my knowledge of this kind of thing, and some people I know are collectors and they know an awful lot about the musicians and the music. I know a drummer in Washington who is a supreme collector. If you ask him a question about a tune he'll tell you who wrote it and when it was recorded and by whom.

MR: Sounds like that fellow Phil Schaap.

DA: Um hum.

MR: He'll give you more information than—

DA: An encyclopedia.

MR: Well I'm interested in that 52nd Street scene. Is that where some of these clubs were?

DA: Jimmy Ryan's I believe was on 52nd Street. And there was also a club across the street called the Club Samoa that we would drop into.

MR: Tamoa?

DA: Samoa.

MR: Samoa.

DA: Yes. It had nothing to do with music.

MR: I see. What would it have cost to get into one of those clubs?

DA: I think the cover charge at Condon's was something like 5 bucks apiece.

MR: Oh that sounds more expensive than I would have thought.

DA: Yeah, well it was a top class club, but there was a cover and sometimes there was like a two drink minimum or something like that, which would take care of the cover, or both. Ryan's was a lot cheaper, I do not remember what that might have cost. Maybe it was a buck. I remember Birdland, where I went to hear Count Basie, had a kind of like a cage area with benches. And that cost 25 cents. But you couldn't get a drink in there and you weren't at a table.

MR: So you could be underage and be in there.

DA: Yes. And that was the attraction of the place.

MR: Did you learn anything from watching those bands operate? Besides just the music.

DA: Oh I think so. I think that unconsciously perhaps, or subconsciously. We were absorbing, I was absorbing how the band was interacting, you know, and how for example there would be a soloist and then maybe two other horn guys would back him up with some kind of a riff. And breaks and tags and all that sort of stuff. The organization of the music was something that I absorbed and then of course you'd hear it again on the records we were playing.

MR: Uh huh. It has a lot more meaning when you see it live.

DA: Yeah. Absolutely.

MR: So at that point, did you have aspirations to be a professional musician?

DA: No. Not at all. I was, you know I had learned, self-taught, learned the ukulele and guitar and I played for high school sing-a-longs and stuff like that. As I said, when I got here I had no idea there was a jazz band or that I would be spending most of my weekends away from Hamilton at other colleges out playing.

MR: That's pretty neat.

DA: It was. It was extremely neat, and of course my college record probably reflects that. I did make it through here with my degree, but Lord knows I don't know how. But it was a fun four years.

MR: What was your major?

DA: English basically. But this was another aspect. I don't know if Hamilton still has Saturday classes, but back in those days we did. I avoided them like the plague. So I tried to organize my schedule so that I never had a class that met on Saturday. And this meant that I had to take some courses that weren't really ones that I would have appreciated. And I didn't stay within the bounds of English, I went history, music, French. So I had, you know, if you will, kind of a broad brush. Yeah I had a broad brush education. It worked because I didn't have to go down to Cornell or someplace like that and get back at two in the morning and get up and go to class.

MR: I think Phil talked about that, that he wasn't quite so smart as to not have Saturday classes.

DA: Well if you're a pre-med student or if you're in the sciences, you know, there's no way around it as I recall. There was always — you'd either have a lab on Saturday or a class or something.

MR: There must have been some wild frat parties you guys played for.

DA: Yes. Yes there were some I remember in particular the Phi Gam House at both Colgate and Cornell. In the spring they had what they called the Fiji Island party. The Phi Gam Fiji. So they all dressed up in sarongs and drank some kind of Hawaiian punch. It got kind of wild. And then some other houses — Colgate had a toga party where they all dressed up like Romans with sheets and stuff like that. Yeah there were some very wild parties. In fact, this is an anecdote, I just recently was talking with the father of one of my relative's wife. Anyway, he went to Cornell at the same time I was at Hamilton. And I said, "Were you in a fraternity?" He said, "Yes." Come to find, I said, "Wasn't that the one that was perched on a hill and every spring house party the guys would slide down the side of this steep hill in a mudslide?" He said, "Yeah," he said, "We really got filthy." Okay, you know, we really laughed about that. I said, "Well do you remember a jazz band playing?" He said, "Oh yeah." I said, "That was me." So anyway, yes, there were some wonderful parties.

MR: So when you came here and you got into the situation you were playing with in a rehearsal, how did you learn the songs?

DA: Mainly off the records. Or, as happens, somebody might know the melody — well Paul Parker would chord it for us and he'd say this is how it goes, and we'd try and get it and he'd say no, no, that's wrong, you know, so we'd learn it that way. But for some reason, and I think it's because of this affinity for music that we all had, and listening to records even before we were in a band, that the tunes were up here. They were already in our heads for some reason. You know. And Em would call, let's do "Nobody's Sweetheart Now," you know, we'd just launch into it. And Mike knew the tune and off we went. I was amazed frequently about how these tunes just sort of came out. And as I said, I did a lot of — not folk — oh yeah, folk songs, sing-a-longs, you know, the old tunes from the 20s and the 30s and 40s. Popular hits like "By the Light of the Silvery Moon" or that stuff. Of course we didn't play that but we did play some other tunes that lodged in my brain somehow.

MR: You are a musical family situation?

DA: Yes. My father played the banjo and the piano in college and wrote, actually wrote the first Tau Kappa Epsilon sweetheart song. All the fraternities had sweetheart songs. And so he wrote that and played ukulele too I guess. And then my mother sang alto in church choirs and gave piano lessons and they met in Florida because my father was soloing in a church on Sunday. And so they married and then my brother was born in '28 and I was

born in ’36 and we moved up north. And my brother was musical, had a great voice, played the trombone and the drums, and so when I came along I learned to play the ukulele and then the guitar. We ended up with a family quartet with four part harmony. And I usually did the chording and sang the melody and my brother would do the bass and my dad would do the high tenor and my mother would do the second tenor. And I learned harmony in a way from that. It was great fun.

MR: That’s excellent ear training.

DA: Yes. Yes. So we did a lot of sitting on the front porch singing songs. And then when I was in high school I was asked frequently to lead sing-a-longs for the boarding students at the school I went to on Sundays, and then we’d just get together in some common room and I’d play the ukulele.

MR: Do you recall what was being played on the radio for the most part, when you were a teenager?

DA: Some of the pop stuff, not very much jazz. I was trying to think of a guy’s name on the way over. I used to listen to him on WNEW every night while I did my homework. And he had a show where he played all kinds of jazz: progressive and big band and some Dixieland. Purple Grotto was the name of the show. Anyway, what was on just the regular pop radio were things like Eartha Kitt, you know, and oh Teresa Brewer, and like I can’t remember, but a lot of the popular songs that had nothing to with jazz. You know it was just pop stuff that came out all the time. And then of course there’d be more classical stuff occasionally — operas on Saturday afternoon, which I rarely listened to.

MR: But you never got the notion to switch to the guitar and play Carl Perkins or Elvis Presley songs?

DA: No. No. Never. In fact I didn’t consider a lot of that music, although Elvis did sing some of these love songs that were popular at one time. He added his own peculiar twist to it. And I thought that was peculiar. Anyway. Let’s see what else was I going to say. Oh yes, in terms of what was going on in the music world as we progressed through college. I was going over to a concert in 19 — I think it was the spring of ’58, maybe the fall, anyway, at Chi Psi they had a stage set up and a band from Syracuse called the Salt City Five was going to be playing. And I had gone over to Syracuse, I’d heard them many times, gone over and sat in with them. They were a wonderful band. And on the way over, blasting out of the DKE house windows was Bill Haley’s “Rock Around the Clock.” And so it was a very interesting bi-play.

MR: I would say so.

DA: So little things like that I remember. But it was fun times.

MR: What was — describe one of your busy weekends with the Catatonic Five.

DA: One I remember in particular, it was because it was strenuous, it was at Cornell, a Cornell frat house party. And we had to go, this was one of the houses, for a Friday night. And that was an 8 to 12 gig. And we didn't have anything until the next evening. So we all came back to Hamilton, drove back to Cornell for a cocktail party at Theta Delph, that started at 6, ended at 8, we had to be at Phi Gam at 9, we played from 9 to 1. We got a few hours' sleep and we got up at 8 o'clock and played for the milk punch party at the D Phi house with the mudslide. So and we got home about 3 o'clock Sunday afternoon just absolutely exhausted. But it was a fun weekend.

MR: What is the recipe for milk punch?

DA: Five gallon milk can and you pour out some of the milk and you replace it with bourbon and ice cream maybe, and maybe a little cognac. And then you'd go around with a big dipper and everybody has a cup. And it usually starts around 10 o'clock in the morning and you know it's starting because you hear guys rapping on the milk can all around the milk can. All around the campuses they'd go through the halls of the dorm: "milk punch, milk punch."

MR: I'll be darned. I wonder if they still do that.

DA: Well you would know wouldn't you?

MR: Well they do have a tradition here at Hamilton, but they don't call it milk punch but it's something. Dick Sherman told me that sometimes you guys got paid with a fifth of good whiskey. Is that true?

DA: That was true. He graduated in '53 you see. So I think back in the earlier 50s, that's how they were paid. But no, we wanted cash. It was a little easier to choose our own booze (for those of us who drank).

MR: So who was your drummer mostly during those years?

DA: Skooky Sherman was the first one, and then he graduated, and then for the times after that we were fortunate to be able to use two drummers from Utica. One of them, I think the first kid was Ronnie Zito who went on, he's now a studio musician and worked with Woody Herman, a wonderful, wonderful drummer. And we couldn't get him for a gig, and he says, "Well I've got this other fella, his name is Jimmy Wormworth, and he'd be more than happy to do it." So we started alternating, you know, using them both. And then when it came time to go to Europe, Ronnie's father was afraid that he was going to — he was sick. He was afraid he was going to pass away while he was in Europe, and then Ronnie wouldn't be able to get home for, whatever. So Ronnie couldn't go to Europe so we took Jimmy. And Jimmy also played with us in Carnegie Hall. And then they both went on the professional careers. Jimmy is still, well both of them are still playing. Jimmy ended up with Lambert, Hendricks & Ross and the Ike Isaacs Trio, and now he works around New York, most recently he did a European tour with Annie Ross.

MR: He did?

DA: Yeah.

MR: That's great. He talked about that, that little stint with you guys on the ship and everything.

DA: We had a very interesting trip through Europe. Well first of all we were over there for two months. We got off the ship and we had an engagement already arranged in Holland. But that got delayed because we needed work permits and we didn't have them. So that was the better part of July that we were involved there, and then around the first of August we rented two Opals and toured around. We went all the way down into Italy and back up through Germany and back to Holland. And then we got back on the boat and came back in September.

MR: Were you playing on those tours?

DA: We had quite a few engagements. The Army hired us in Koblenz. We played on street corners in Paris and got arrested. We played on the Grand Canal in Venice and the police came along and said, "Please would you move to the next obelisk because you're disturbing the symphony orchestra in the main square." But we just had a hat on the floor. And then when we got back to Holland we were asked to go to a hotel up in the very north of Holland. And we played for teenagers in the afternoon and then played for adults in the evening and the owner of the hotel put us up for the night and paid our train fare back and forth, and we got a little pay. So but the stint in Europe, in Holland that is, was two weeks. And that was really the only formal engagement we had lined up before we went.

MR: And the thing at Carnegie Hall was when you came back?

DA: When we came back it was the following November.

MR: I see.

DA: Yeah, we got that job through the auspices of a fellow named Dave Cook, a clarinet player with the Dartmouth Indian Chiefs, which was a band that was one of our — I wouldn't say rivals because we operated in a different market. But he had suggested to Jim Carpenter, who was running these college jazz bands that go to Carnegie Hall that we were a pretty good band and give us a try. So we did and they did, and we ended up playing opposite an all-star band from the Central Plaza in New York. We played two sets each and then had one set together. And that was quite an experience.

MR: I'll bet.

DA: Standing on the stage at Carnegie Hall. Great things have happened here, people who have stood on the stage.

MR: Did the college take note of that?

DA: Yes, they did, but not really as much as I would have liked. It was over Thanksgiving holiday and people could have gone but we didn't have a good showing from Hamilton people, and from my high school I would say that Carnegie Hall was not full by any means.

MR: I'm curious as to your relationship, the band in general, with the college. Was there a relationship? Did you have anything to do with the music department?

DA: No not really. We were pretty much on our own. I will say that a lot of the faculty were sympathetic to our schedule if you will. I remember in a couple of instances having an assignment due on Monday and to go to the professor and say, you know, the band. And he'd say okay, turn it in Tuesday. And that was great, to get that kind of leniency. And Dean Tolles was very sympathetic, and some of the other professors thought well this is a good thing for the school, even though these kids are on the brink of ruin. Except Emerson was a very bright guy. I think that if he said Donn is going to go play someplace then they kind of let us. But I think that may have had something to do with how I got through this place, was having a sympathetic ear among the faculty and including the dean. In fact, I remember right after I joined the band and we started playing around and I believe it was a winter party, February of 1965, and Dean Tolles came over along with most of the faculty for a cocktail party at the Alpha Delta house which was kind of a tradition. And I remember the description, I don't know if you heard Phil Mead's speech today, but he was talking about the suit he always wore, and he was in a rumpled tie and a rumpled shirt and everything. And I remember he was standing there with some kind of liquid in his left hand and a cigarette in his right hand, and the ashes dribbling down his tie. And he says, "Donn, you know, your grades aren't what they should be. I really think you ought to stop this music business." And I said, "Well, Dean, you know, I'm on scholarship. I understand that I have to keep my grades up but also I am working at the house as a waiter, and so I need that little bit of money." And he said, "Well if you have a problem come and see me." Well I never had to. But I think he kept an eye on me, which he did for everybody, as everybody knows. He was a friend.

MR: And you were in a fraternity.

DA: Yes. Alpha Delta.

MR: And how were the fraternities different back then.

DA: Well we were a lot freer in our activities, although the college really didn't like some of the partying that went on. Although at house party time a lot was forgiven. You know I mean the ladies, the dates were housed in the fraternity houses and all the guys had to move out and bunk in the dorms someplace. And so that was an interesting aspect to it. Another interesting aspect was the fact that every house, having a house party with dates in it, had to have a chaperone couple. And the chaperones all met with Sid and Ellie

Wertimer sometime on Friday before the party started, and rules were laid down. And it was pretty much controlled I would say. We had beer available in the house, we had a refrigerator downstairs, so there wasn't a taboo on that at all. Some of the fraternities were a little wilder than others, depending upon the make-up of the people in it. And in our particular house we had all kinds of people. We had the athletes, we had the scholars, a Rhodes Scholar in one case, musicians, concert guys, you know the choir. We had 65 members at one time, and some of them lived in the dorms but we had to have every bed in the house occupied to keep up with the bills. Anyway, I don't really know about the fraternity aspect now, I just know that I wish that the fraternity system had not been changed to the extent that it has been. I do get regular reports from my Alpha Delta Phi fraternity here, members and what they're doing, and really concentrating on literary means, and they're thinking about if the college will let them do it, with the national fraternity's assistance, buying a place where they could have meetings off campus. And of course what everyone's afraid of there in the administration would be that these would be party holes. So I don't really think it's ever going to happen but right now the Samuel Eels Memorial Hall was the Alpha Delta House. And it's been since bought by the college for an unbelievably low amount of money. They expanded it and it's really a beautiful place, but every time I go in there a lot of the downstairs is still exactly the same: the wallpaper and all that stuff. It really is a very nice place to live and I lived there for 2-1/2 years.

MR: Was the drinking age 21?

DA: No. 18.

MR: It was 18? And then it went up?

DA: I don't know when. That's why —

MR: No, no, no, I'm wrong. It's 21 now. It changed in the early 80s or something.

DA: And New York was one of the last to change as I recall. It was no problem with that. In fact I would venture to say that some of the drinking at colleges today is perhaps because of the age limit. You know they sneak around and they get perhaps a little more than they should. And there's trouble. But most of the guys here, because it's an isolated school, if we had a house party and people were drinking, it was here. It stayed here. It's kind of like what happens in Vegas stays in Vegas. Well same thing here at Hamilton. If you went down the hill you might not come back up.

MR: At the time did you feel like it was isolated here?

DA: Yeah sometimes I did, in good weather anyway. Friday afternoons somebody would say, "rollin'" or "wheels up" and off we would go to Skidmore or Wells. Ninety miles, it didn't matter. Sometimes we even went to Cazenovia.

MR: That's a girl's school, right?

DA: Yes it was. It may still be, I don't know. It was a junior college then.

MR: Do you remember what your tuition was in those years?

DA: Let's see. The figure 7 hundred dollars for tuition strikes a bell. And that, coupled with the room and board, which was a whole different billing, ended up to be around 11 hundred, 12 hundred dollars. And I was on a half tuition scholarship, and I had a job in the fraternity the whole time I was here doing one thing or another. So it was about eleven hundred, and as Phil said today in his speech, next year's tuition and board and room is 49 thousand. That's a hunk of change. But even then you know, 11 hundred dollars was not exorbitant, certainly. But it was still cheaper to go to a public college or a university.

MR: Is there something you got from Hamilton that you can put into words that really made a difference for you in your career?

DA: I think the thing that strikes me most is a feeling of, one independence, and two being able to accomplish something. Yeah, it was the perseverance aspect. And part of that was the college itself and part of it due to professors really pushing you to do well, and appreciating it, and telling you so if you did well. And the other aspect of course was being involved with a jazz band and booking gigs and making arrangements and all of that, which is kind of like running a business. And I was not a businessman. I went into the federal government. You don't have to be a businessman to be in the federal government.

MR: Did you ever have personality clashes in the band?

DA: No.

MR: Wow. That's saying something.

DA: I know. And the same thing has held true in the band that I've been most recently associated with in Washington, the Federal Jazz Commission. There has never been, to my knowledge, any kind of open dispute really about anything. And of course I'm just a sideman and I have known the leader for many, many years and worked in the band 18 years, but he had that band for I guess 30, so I don't know all of the history of all of that, but generally speaking at Hamilton no there wasn't any problem. Unless somebody couldn't make a gig, which happened. And then there was no animosity about it. I can't make it. I either got another gig or I've got class or something.

MR: So some of the guys played with other groups too on occasion?

DA: Well only the drummer. Only the drummer. Jimmy and Ronnie. They played all over the place. But then again when I had to hire somebody to get them to play with the band, they might have been from, you know, like Syracuse, from another band. And we had, and you may be familiar with these names, but we had a gig in Elmira and needed a piano and a bass player and Jimmy Wormworth was playing drums and so he said how about these

guys. And I said well who are they? And he said well it's Ron Carter on bass and Gap Mangione on piano. Chuck Mangione's brother.

MR: No kidding.

DA: So we played at Elmira College, it was a rainy day, and when the Dixieland stopped there was a nice little trio of Carter, Mangione and Jimmy Wormworth. And of course I love that because, as I say, I did like that kind of music. There's a little, well Gap Mangione was a fine piano player. Very esoteric.

MR: Ron Carter must have been at Eastman at that time.

DA: I guess so yeah.

MR: Yeah, he spent some time in Rochester.

DA: Yeah and I bought a couple of his CDs, and frankly, I like the way he played back then better than, of course he's recognized as one of the premier bassists in the world. And there were a couple of other instances where we had to bring in somebody else, and it's just been a lot of phone calls and making sure that they get picked up or whatever. And that was the trying part of it, it wasn't a very simple thing. Transportation was a bug because I didn't have a car and I had to borrow cars all the time and I once, I think I was talking to Phil and I said, "You know, why don't we go buy a used hearse? It's big, you could fit the whole band in there, you know, we'd paint it or put something in the windows." So when I got home on vacation I asked my mother if she would loan me some money to buy a vehicle. And she said, "What?" And I said I'd like to buy a used hearse." She said, "Absolutely not. I will not have a hearse parked anywhere near my house."

MR: I can't say as a blame her.

DA: No. Anyway.

MR: Even if you dress it up, it's still a hearse. We mentioned a person we both know, Dave Robinson. And I'm sure you know him through the Dixieland circles down there. I saw him at, I think it was two years ago at a jazz educators' conference and he was speaking on a panel and the title of the panel was "Trad Jazz is Alive and Well." And I said, "Did you come up with that title?" And he said, "No, someone else did." You know so he had to address this thing, and actually I don't know that he actually agreed with the title. So my long intro is, do you think, is there a reason that Dixieland jazz doesn't seem to have the attention paid to it that almost any other style of jazz does?

DA: I don't know why. I understand what you're saying and yes it's absolutely true. I mean some of the music that becomes popular and stays popular attracts a larger audience and more money as well. I mean stadiums full of people for Springsteen and things like that. As I said, Carnegie Hall wasn't full when we played there. But I have no idea. A lot of people say it sounds so much the same. Whatever tune you play, whether it's fast or slow,

even a specific melody, it still sounds the same. Well it's got a structure to it. You know? And if you stay pretty much within that structure it's going to sound a little bit alike. The interplay between the horns and the rhythm section that's playing behind them, and sometimes the tune itself will be without any solos, it'll be all ensemble, with the horns in three part harmony or sometimes unison, but I just don't know. I think that's what somebody said to me. Now Dave Robinson has had this youth group. It used to be called the Federal Focus. And I got them to change it because there was a conflict with our band in the name. So they changed it to oh, Potomoc Focus, I don't know what it's called now. But anyway, he's had a couple of very good musicians come out of that band, and one of them I remember, a drummer, Brad Hunter, anyway, he worked with the Federal Jazz Commission once or twice, and I asked him, I said, "Aren't you working?" He said, "No. There's no call for this music." But another player, a clarinet player, a lady, Hallie Schoenberg, is playing. But she's not playing Dixieland. She's playing with trios and quartets doing essentially I guess what you call jazz, what they call jazz. Nowhere near traditional. So it's a mystery.

MR: I feel like Dixieland is very happy music most of the time?

DA: Um hum.

MR: And sometimes I feel like that works against it because if it's so happy it's not really serious. And maybe it's not worthy of study or, I don't know either.

DA: Well I would agree with you and that's probably why a lot of what we would consider icons of the music, you know people like Condon or Wild Bill Davison or King Oliver or Louis Armstrong, haven't been recognized — except Louis was world famous — but I mean have not been recognized outside of a small group of the public for the type of musician and quality musician that they were. And I think that's really too bad. I mentioned Wild Bill Davison to somebody who was a Springsteen fan for example. He said, "Who? What? When?" You know? Absolutely no knowledge. But I will tell you that probably some classical musicians that play in the philharmonic orchestras and stuff like that, they probably know these names. Because they are good musicians themselves and they recognize the talent.

MR: In the years you were here, obviously some members graduated and stuff. Was there competition to get into the Catatonic Five?

DA: Yes there was. There were a horn player and a piano player, and they went off to form their own band, and then when we needed a piano player sometimes we used this one fellow. But the other guy on trumpet was not really tuned in that much. In fact, for a couple of years and when we went to Europe and when we went to Carnegie Hall, our piano player and trumpet player were from Colgate. And I don't know how that happened. I mean we were desperate for a musician, a piano player and a trumpet player,

in September of whatever year it was that they joined the band. And I guess Emerson knew somebody at Colgate and said, "Gee do you know any guys that play," and they said, "Yeah there's these two guys. They're both pretty good, the piano player is extraordinary, exceptional." So he went to Europe with us but he couldn't make the Carnegie Hall gig so we used another fellow who was part of the original Catatonic Five, Derry Hall, who was from Clinton. So I have to say that while a lot of the people here at Hamilton, the students, really liked the band — in fact we played for the college more than two or three occasions, big concerts, important concerts, jazz concert weekend for example — but the students were so busy with their studies. I mean even my roommate said, "How do you do this? How can you go to school, how can you pass this course if you're out playing jazz all the time." I mean they liked it and appreciated that somebody was doing it, but they weren't interested in trying. They left their horns at home when they went to college.

MR: What did your mother say about it?

DA: All I remember her saying, and this is kind of strange, she said, "Why are you taking English?" Now she, both my parents were very happy that I was playing music. They had no idea really of how much traveling I was doing back and forth. And we never got in any trouble and we only had a couple of car accidents.

MR: Only a couple.

DA: Only a couple.

MR: I heard this story last night about coming back from, I think it was Cornell, and some Great Dane puppy ended up in the car? Was this before or after you?

DA: I think it was before me. I don't remember any Great Dane puppy.

MR: All right. It was called Moose or something.

DA: Oh no, that was Emerson's dog. It wasn't a Great Dane, it was a sandy colored mutt. And yeah, and Emerson would take the dog with him on gigs. And I don't know, there were some problems sometimes and Moose would jump out of the car I guess. But we did have fun.

MR: And when you got out did you find other playing opportunities pretty steadily?

DA: As a matter of fact no. After I got out in '58 I found myself in a position of possibly being drafted. And so I joined the Army so I could go to the language school. And I did that, and I picked the language that I thought would land me in Germany, where I wanted to go, and they sent me to Fort Meade instead. So I ended up going to Fort Meade and then becoming a civilian at the same agency. And that's where I worked for 38 years.

MR: I see. You did a two year stint?

DA: No three. When you enlisted you had to go for three but then you got three years of inactive reserve which meant I didn't have to go to meetings. But in answer to your

question of whether or not I continued playing, well I had my banjo sent out to Monterey and the language I was taking, which was Czech, we had a little song session on Friday afternoon. And I would play the banjo and we had a bass player and another guitar player so we played along for Czech folk songs. But there was no opportunity for a band or anything like that. And when I got to the Washington area things were kind of in the doldrums which was in 1960, and I honestly cannot remember when my first paying gig occurred back in Maryland. I only remember who it was with. But things sort of came along, and musicians get to be known and then you'd have these big jam sessions and people will hire you or they'll form a band. And we had a lot of small bands around in the seventies. And then I joined a band called Southern Comfort and then from there I went on assignment overseas and when I got back I joined the Federal Jazz Commission. But right after college no, there was nothing going on. In fact, because the music picture had changed in the public arena, in other words had gone to Bill Haley and that kind of music, even the Dixieland revival dried up in New York. And that was the end of that style of music. And I wasn't about to join the Presley crowd.

MR: I see. Not even tempted.

DA: Not even. No.

MR: When you get in a situation, I mean I always felt like the rhythm players, the bass and the guitar and the banjo — how do I put this — you have to know a song better than the horn players. That's how I felt in that situation. Because horn players can find single notes, they can sort of meander their way through things, but you guys have to play the correct changes and stuff.

DA: Oh yeah that's very true. The rhythm section, even the drummer. I judge the quality of a drummer by the way that he plays the tune, the accents that he puts in at the right place at the right time. And some drummers are good drummers but they just don't have a feel for the music or they don't know the tune. But as far as people who are doing notes, like me, the chords, Gordy on the tuba, or the bass player, you really have to know the tune pretty well. Because if you don't play the right changes you can throw the lead horn off something terribly. And I have a friend that says when I do on salad sometimes sounds like chord salad. When I'm doing chords sometimes I screw them up so badly that it sounds like chord salad.

MR: Well if you have a good bass player or tuba man, and you can rely on them hitting that downbeat note, but if they're not then it can be hairy.

DA: That's absolutely right. Sometimes you know you're both feeding off of each other and if you both don't know the tune very well it's not fun.

MR: Right. Is there a — in swing oriented we have the "Real Book," sort of the Bible of — is there a quote "Real Book" of Dixieland tunes? Twenty songs that everybody should know?

DA: Well yeah there is. There are fake books that are called fake books that have many different tunes in them. And sometimes in a music store it'll say you know "21 most favorite Dixieland tunes." And I'll look through it and say they're not my favorites. You know sure, there are these around. And there are some core tunes that everybody knows, mostly, and we sometimes refer to them a vanilla, because they're just standards, chestnuts if you will. And they're the ones that we probably played in the Catatonic Five when we first started out and then developed our own book of tunes that we played and arrangements and things.

MR: Did the group in Washington ever — I'll rephrase — is there such a thing as new Dixieland tunes? Are people writing that you are aware of.

DA: There have been some tunes written more recently than, yeah I would say, tunes that might have been written in the 70s and 80s or even the 90s. Somebody wrote a tune for "Southern Comfort at Shakey's," or "A Night at Shakey's" or something like that. And it was kind of like a standard Dixieland tune, you know, like the chestnut if you will, and that's why they're unremarkable, because they sound so much like something else. But no, there's nobody really trying to do that because there's no market.

MR: What do you think of what Jim Cullum does?

DA: I don't know, I like that thing. In fact I have something for you, it's a CD by a fellow who used to be our clarinet player Ron Hockett, who plays for Jim Cullum now and played with us for many years and I also played with Ron on other gigs with other bands. I think he spent his whole career in Washington in the Marines, in the Marine band. So Arbors Records has published something called "Finally Ron" and it's his own quartet or quintet I guess. It's very nice stuff. So I have one of those for you. But Cullum is a very colorful guy. He's also kind of a strict disciplinarian I understand. But I have played with him a couple of times when he showed up in Washington and came and sat in for a couple of numbers. But that's really the extent.

MR: Are you familiar with Béla Fleck?

DA: Oh yeah. I don't know how to explain that guy. He is an incredible musician. And picking the banjo as his lead instrument, really, he plays some outrageous stuff.

MR: He sure does. He's got outrageous musicians with him too.

DA: Oh yeah.

MR: He's been here a couple of times.

DA: Really?

MR: He's quite popular.

DA: Good for him. I've never seen him in person though. Pardon me, I'm drying up here.

MR: Well is there anything that you make sure that you wanted to clear up about the history of the Alumni Jazz Band?

DA: Well I think that probably the highlight of our career were the two things that we did in 1956 and that was the trip to Europe and all things associated with that and then the Carnegie Hall concert. And how those two things happened I explained about the Carnegie Hall thing. The boat trip to Europe, back in those years, '55 may have been the first year, the Holland America line was running student sailings. They had 800 students crammed on an old liberty ship. And the Tigertown Five from Princeton played the year before and I read about that someplace and I was chatting about this in the fraternity house one day and mentioned the Holland America line and one of my fraternity brothers a classmate, Freddie Ridman said, "Well my grandfather founded the line, do you think you guys might want to play on it?" Holy cow. So I said, "Sure, would you ask whoever you need to ask whether or not we can have an audition and take a chance on it?" He said, "Sure," and he came back and said, "here's the name of the guy to call." So I called him up and wrote him a letter and said this is who we are and we'd like to try out and be part of one of these student sailings. And we went down to Hoboken and auditioned. And the guy heard two tunes and said, "You're hired." So you know we got on the boat at the end of June and played every day, every evening, and whenever they wanted us to play. And we had cabins and it was free passage back and forth on these two Dutch liners. And so that was very exciting and it was a lot of fun of course with all the kids. There are some stories about it which I won't go into right now but leading up to that I was reading in *Time* magazine, there was a Dutch piano player, a lady named Pia Beck, who was in New York while I was gone on Christmas vacation. So I read about her, something about her, "Dutch Dynamite" or whatever. And I called the William Morris Agency and said, "I'd like to get in touch with this lady." So they gave me her telephone number and I called her and I said, "I'm in a college jazz band and we're going on the Holland America Lines and we're going to be in Rotterdam on such and such a —." "Oh you must come and play in my club." So we did that. And we had contracts with the club before we went over and then I said earlier that we had trouble with working permits. And we finally played and we played at three different clubs every night, three sets in each club, and so we got back to the apartment in the Hague at dawn. But it was fun.

MR: You did three clubs in a row?

DA: Yeah, they were all in the same building. So we played there. One was called the Flying Dutchman, another was called Scheherazade, and the other one was called The Galleries. The Galleries was a great big club with posh curtains and stuff. And we were a show band. And so that was that. And Dick Sherman wasn't with us on that but Phil was and he

remembers those things, but they know very little about the work-up to it. I said, "Wow, we're going to Europe and this is when we leave" and all of that, but they had no idea about the contracts and the stuff like that. So that's an aspect that, as I said, it was like going to business school.

MR: Yeah. That's quite an accomplishment.

DA: It was fun.

MR: It's sort of a leap of faith to get on the boat and, well, let's see what happens. I heard something about your banjo broke when you got on the ship somehow.

DA: Yes. We played on the dock as the kids were coming onboard, and then we put our instruments away and we were supposed to play at 8 o'clock that night in the lounge. So we got up to the lounge and I opened the case and I lifted the neck of the banjo and it came right off the rest of it. And there I was with strings and the banjo in two parts. Fortunately the social chairman, the Dutch guy who was in charge of us, saw my predicament. We went downstairs immediately, down in the front, the bow of the ship, to the carpenter shop. And they jabbered in Dutch and I said yeah, okay. So I came back two days later and it had been glued together and they had it in a vise and this was one of those, I don't know, antiques, which it's still in one piece today. And it suffered through the whole trip to Europe and all that. But talk about here we are underway, we've already gone out to sea and I don't have an instrument. So I had a couple of nights off.

MR: You become the social chairman.

DA: Yeah.

MR: Well it's been fascinating talking to you.

DA: It's been a pleasure.

MR: I know we've both got class dinners to get to.

DA: Yes.

MR: I hope you have a good gig tonight. You guys always seem to rise to the occasion.

DA: I think we'll have fun and it'll be another good time. And I want to thank you for your time.

MR: Okay.

DA: And maybe we'll see you later?

MR: You will.

DA: Great. Thank you very much.